

BY DIPANKAR GUPTA

In the early 1950s, Milovan Djilas, the famous intellectual of what was once Yugoslavia, said with utmost certitude that India would not last the decade as a unified nation-state. It gives me a sense of perverse pleasure that while Yugoslavia was slashed to bloody bits and has now disappeared without a trace, India is still around and good for many more years.

The very existence of India and its coming into late middle age convincingly demonstrate that the textbook notions of the nation-state are grossly in error. The belief that European nation-states came into being because they were fired by the energies of a single language and religion is wildly off the mark. At the time of the French Revolution, less than 18 per cent of the population spoke French. When Italy was formed, Massimo

d'Azeglio said that now that Italy was made it was about time to make Italians. It is said that less than 2 per cent of Italians spoke Italian at the time of its nativity.

Instead of such facts doing the rounds, we were subjected to stylised versions of the western nation-state that made us a little shamefaced about the prospects of a united India. Our colonial masters consistently sowed this doubt in us for it justified their plotted manoeuvres at divide and rule. Before they were finally relieved of their burden, they issued the dire warning that the "men of straw", who were succeeding them, lacked the stuffing to govern India. Communities and castes would soon fall upon each other without the restraining hand of the British. Soon, India would break up into bite-sized pieces and any memory of its once unified past could hardly be served up with any conviction.

As if on tap, riots broke just before and after the declaration of Independence, lending credence to the view that India's career as a nation-state was over even before it got started. Sadly, a large number of Indian scholars too bought into this line of thinking and won a fair amount of praise from the western press and academia.

But India fought off the so-called fissiparous forces with relative ease. In the initial years, however, even the stalwarts of the Independence movement were a little unsure of themselves. This is not surprising, given the din around them predicting India's imminent collapse. That is why, when the cry went up for linguistic states in the early 1950s, many Congress leaders opposed it, but with one eye on the political barometer. They had not quite forgotten that from the 1920s the national movement had promised such linguistic

states once India became Independent. To recoil from the suggestion now did not quite sit right with the popular urges outside that had already taken to the streets.

But after Bombay state was bifurcated into Gujarat and Maharashtra, and after Haryana and Punjab were carved out of the old Punjab, and so on, the worst fears of the centrists were easily allayed. Once these states were formed, their protagonists returned to routine politics. The motley coalitions that they had established for this cause soon came unstuck. The campaign was over and it was time to bring the posters

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down. It was not as if the success at establishing linguistic states would give their protagonists second wind to press on for a sovereign Maharashtra, Gujarat or Punjab, as some feared they would. The matter ended there and the heat of the partisans had turned cold.

The delay in the formation of linguistic states was quite unnecessary. Those at the helm of affairs should have known better than to drag their feet at a genuine democratic demand to be

